

er one at a time until Device Manager no longer lists the unknown device. Or, if you know what hardware is causing the error, verify that the hardware is working and that you have all the correct and updated drivers for the OS. Install the drivers through the Add Hardware Wizard.

1.6 Troubleshooting the Blue Screen Of Death

One of the most dreaded error messages for a Windows user is the blue screen, or the Blue Screen of Death (BSOD) as it is popularly known, which suddenly pops up informing you that something is seriously wrong with Windows. What this screen essentially means is that Windows has crashed and needs to reboot to recover. Usually, you will be able to recover and continue without any problems, but it can sometimes be a hair-raising experience—like when you're pressed for time and have to get that PowerPoint presentation ready for your boss!

Windows 9x/ME

In Windows 9x/ME this error is less serious but more common. You can usually recover from the error by simply pressing [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [Del] and restarting the computer, or by switching off the PC and switching it back on. However, the error message will contain very little information that you can use in troubleshooting.

1.6.1 Problems causing the BSOD

The BSOD is the main way for virtual device drivers to report a problem. The error description will state that Windows faced a problem (exception) at a particular memory address (a portion of the RAM) in a certain file, usually with the prefix VxD (virtual device driver), or the file name may have the DLL extension. At the minimum, it indicates that there was a problem with that particular file. Typically, this may have been caused by some action of the user that Windows does not allow—like accessing a document from a floppy and then removing the floppy before closing document. In other cases it may indicate that there is a problem with a